intertwined with legitimacy. Preferential treatment for populist states, such as doling out concessions or other benefits, can undermine trust among member states, especially those that view such actions as inequitable or ethically dubious. This perception can erode the integrity of IO decision-making processes and fuel resentment. Critics may interpret these concessions as bribes or instances of corruption, damaging the IO's standing. For instance, the WTO has faced backlash for privileging small, exclusive groups of powerful states in trade negotiations, while eschewing broader membership discussions (Davis 2003). Similarly, the IMF has been accused of favoritism, particularly toward US allies, prompting questions about the organization's impartiality and fairness (Stone 2011).

Such appeasement strategies risk undermining the premise of IO legitimacy: the idea that states participate because they recognize IOs as rightful arbiters in global politics (Hurd 1999; Buchanan and Keohane 2006). IOs are meant to deliver collective benefits and welfare-enhancing outcomes to their members (Pollack 1997). Visible appeasement strategies, however, may create the impression that IOs cater disproportionately to the loudest or most demanding members, weakening trust among observers—whether member states, domestic publics, or elite stakeholders like NGOs.

Secrecy presents another challenge to legitimacy, particularly by casting doubt on the fairness and transparency of IO processes. When IOs obscure the decision-making mechanisms behind their actions, they undermine the public's ability to assess their processes and decisions. Transparency and inclusivity are cornerstones of democratic governance, and their absence in IO operations can lead to skepticism and diminished trust. If stakeholders suspect that IO decisions are being made behind closed doors, without accountability, it becomes harder to maintain confidence in these institutions.

Conversely, strategic efforts to bolster transparency and expand outreach to domestic audiences can enhance IO legitimacy. By engaging directly with citizens, explaining decisions in clear and accessible terms, and demonstrating the tangible benefits of their work, IOs can counter populist narratives that frame them as elitist or out-of-touch. Similarly, efforts to curb member states' disengagement or withdrawal while maintaining fairness can reinforce the perception that IOs are functional, unified, and essential components of global governance.